

Brainstorming

Defer judgement · go for quantity · build on ideas · welcome wild ideas

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Brainstorming is group idea-generation governed by four rules: **defer judgement**, **strive for quantity**, **build on the ideas of others** and **encourage wild ideas**. Separating generation from evaluation lets a group produce more and more original options than criticism-as-you-go allows.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Formalised by advertising executive Alex Osborn in *Applied Imagination* (1953), who coined the term.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Osborn observed that premature criticism strangled idea flow in meetings. His rules were designed to suspend judgement long enough for quantity — and therefore quality — to emerge.

HOW IT IS USED

A facilitator states the challenge and rules, the group generates freely against a quota, all ideas are captured visibly, and evaluation happens only afterward in a separate convergent step.

WHEN IT IS USED

The Ideate phase, and any point where a wide option space is needed.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, product and creative teams, and students.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It was the first explicit attempt to **engineer group creativity** with rules; later methods (brainwriting, HMW) refine its known weaknesses while keeping its core principle of deferred judgement.

FIGURE 1 · OSBORN'S FOUR RULES



Figure 1. Many ideas radiate from one challenge, generated under Osborn's four rules.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

6-3-5 Brainwriting *Slibrary 2*

SCAMPER *Slibrary 1*

Worst Possible Idea *Slibrary 7*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Osborn, A.F. (1953) *Applied Imagination*. New York: Scribner.

Paulus, P.B. and Nijstad, B.A. (eds.) (2003) *Group Creativity*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.